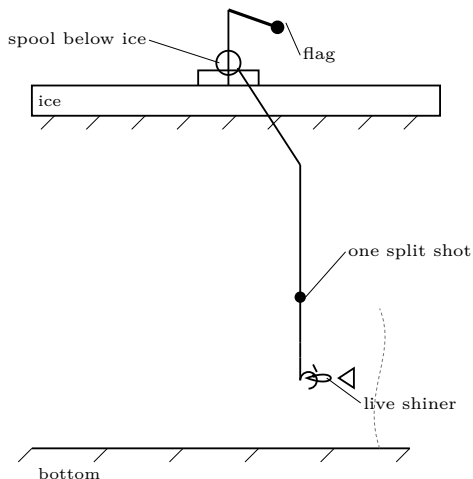


Tip-Up

Winter pike and walleye

Fish live bait under the ice while you fish somewhere else



What it does

A spool of line sits in the water below the ice, where it cannot freeze. A trigger holds a spring-loaded flag down; when a fish runs, the spool turns, the trigger releases and the flag springs up.

Why it matters

You can cover several holes at once and jig a different one while they fish for you. Wisconsin allows multiple lines — confirm the current number before you set them.

Components

Tip-up, 20–30 lb braided tip-up line, wire or fluorocarbon leader, split shot, single hook or quick-strike rig.

Leader

Wire for pike, always. 12–15 lb fluorocarbon for walleye.

Bait

A lively 4–6 in shiner or sucker, hooked lightly through the back just behind the dorsal so it swims.

Depth

Set it 12–18 in off the bottom, or just above the weed tops.

Set it

1. Drill the hole and clear the slush completely, or the flag will freeze down and never trip.
2. Drop the baited rig until it touches bottom, then reel up 12–18 in and mark that line depth with a rubber band or a clip so you can reset the same depth all day.
3. Set the trigger with the flag bent under it. Test it once by hand — a trigger set too tight will not release for a fish.
4. Bank snow around the base of the tip-up to keep the hole from refreezing.

When the flag goes

Walk, do not run

Footsteps on clear ice carry. Approach quietly, especially in shallow water.

Watch the spool

If it is still turning, the fish is moving. Let it run. If it has stopped, wait until it starts again — that is the fish turning the bait.

Set by hand

Pick the line up off the spool, take up slack until you feel the fish, and pull firmly hand over hand. There is no rod to absorb a snap, so a smooth strong pull is correct.

Bring it up hand over hand

Lay line on the ice away from the hole so it cannot tangle back down.

Where

Pine spots **1**, **6** and **9** over weed edges in 8–15 ft; North spots **1** and **5**. Pike season closes 7 March — check the current dates.

ICE IS NEVER GUARANTEED

No ice is safe ice. Check thickness yourself as you go rather than trusting somebody else's report; four inches of clear ice is a common minimum for one person on foot, and more for a group. Springs, inlets, outlets and current thin the ice unpredictably — on North Lake the river inflow and outflow at spots **2** and **6** are exactly the places to stay off. Carry ice picks around your neck, take a rope, and do not go out alone.

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